
Review

Reviewed Work(s): African Dance: An Artistic, Historical and Philosophical Inquiry by Kariamuwelsh Asante

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*AFRICAN DANCE: AN ARTISTIC,
HISTORICAL AND PHILOSOPHICAL INQUIRY*

254 pp., with illustrations

Kariamuwelsh Asante (ed.)

African World Press, Inc: Trenton, New Jersey, 1996,

\$16.95, £11.99 (p/b)

(Distributed in Europe by Turnaround)

It is widely held that religion in Africa cannot be separated from other aspects of life. One cannot read this book without reaching a similar conclusion. Kariamuwelsh Asante has skilfully organised the contributions into a multi-faceted analysis of African culture by focusing specifically on the medium of dance, which the contributors to the volume link in various ways with religious expressions. This is accomplished under four headings all dealing with tradition. The first examines tradition itself followed by sections on tradition and continuity, tradition transformed and tradition contextualised.

The pervasiveness of religion in African culture is made particularly clear in the first article by the late Pearl Primus, to whom the book is dedicated. Primus provides the reader with a vivid sense of what it feels like to experience African dance, which she describes as being so 'hypnotic' that it draws the dancer 'nearer and nearer to the centre of 'All-Being''. This is why, Primus argues, those who wish to understand African dance should learn also about African religions.

This theme of a holistic world-view in traditional Africa is supported in a subsequent article by Doris Green who describes African dance as imitating all aspects of life including eating, pounding corn, hunting, fishing, self-defence and sexual activity. She also draws attention to the importance of dancing in connection with life cycle rituals, particularly those surrounding puberty. Esilokun Kinni-Olusanyin follows this theme by demonstrating how the central feature of the drum in African ritual dances contributes to a holistic experience by forming a complete expression of 'symmetrical, consonant concert of sound and animated movement, colour and form'.

Robert Nicholls of the University of the Virgin Islands introduces the section on 'Tradition and Continuity' by arguing that indigenous cultures are 'functional social instruments' that over

time learned to cope with differing environments, some of which were quite extreme. Traditional African art, he asserts, likewise is entirely functional. For this reason, dance in Africa is associated with rituals which function in society to provide periodic renewal for the community, for example, in planting and harvesting ceremonies, new year festivals and in rites of passage.

In his article entitled 'African Dance: Bridges to Humanity', Tracy Snipe concurs with Nicholls that art in Africa cannot be separated from the needs of the community and its adaptation to the environment. He introduces, however, a helpful analysis of dance and religion in the 'New World' by reviewing the trans-cultural influences of African ritual dance. This can be witnessed, he says, in the persistent practice of Voodoo in the United States, in many of the rituals of the Catholic Church in South America and in Yoruba dances still performed in 'New World' countries such as Cuba, Brazil and Trinidad. A short article by Myriam Evelyse Mariani substantiates Snipe's analysis by focusing specifically on African influences in Brazilian dance.

As traditional African dance evolved, particularly in the Americas, it has undergone a transformation from its inextricable connection to religion into forms which are quite secular. This change is documented historically in an article by Katrina Hazzard-Gordon who traces its origin to the middle passage. By the time the first Africans were born in North America, she argues, this process was already quite advanced. 'By the early eighteenth century the sacred-secular split was fairly well established with respect to dance.' What became most critical for the development of African dance in North America was not its traditional African religious roots, but the slave experience itself and its ensuing 'slave dances'. The twentieth century has featured further transformations in African dance in its North American context. These are exemplified in 'dance story' and in 'tap dance', two forms popularised among African-Americans but which are rooted in what Cheryl Willis calls in her article an 'African aesthetic'.

Contextualisation refers to the manner in which a cultural expression, in this case African dance, adapts and responds dynamically to new cultural influences. In the first of three articles exploring this phenomenon, Felix Begho describes the West African context in which traditional dances (divided by Begho into the categories of sacred, ceremonial and entertainment) have been

modified in contemporary circumstances by 'the cultural clash of colonial and post-colonial society'. Innovations in traditional sacred dances have been affected by the Independent Churches, particularly the Aladura (so-called spirit-type), through dances inducing trances and visions. Traditional ceremonial dances have been revived under the influence of new African governments which have tried to instil in their people a renewed sense of cultural pride. Entertainment dances have incorporated aspects of the sacred and ceremonial dances by making them into voices of social protest and cultural renewal. These have also been accompanied by night club show dances, street entertainers' dances and puppet theatre dances.

Contextualisation is examined by Omofolabo Soyinka Ajayi as a contest between African indigenous religions and Christianity and Islam, the two dominant missionary religions which invaded Africa. Ajayi argues that dance in Africa, as both a sign and a vehicle of communication, provided a vital traditional means for establishing commerce between the human community and sacred realities. When Christian missionaries came to Africa, they brought with them a Western attitude which Ajayi labels as 'anti-body' and hence as 'anti-dance'. This resulted in the suppression of traditional African dance forms. Although Islam adapted to traditional African cultures in many ways, its prohibition against human representation affected African dance, drama and sculpture negatively. Despite the history of Christian and Islamic suppression of African dance, Ajayi concludes that it survives in many forms, not the least in new forms of Christianity and in culturally contextualised Islamic practices.

The final article in the section on contextualisation, by Kariamu Welsh Asante, examines two dance forms in Zimbabwe, the *Jerusarema* and the *Muchongoyo*. Each expresses aspects of African rhythm, such as the use of flat-footed, gliding steps, frequently discharged from a crouched position, and performed 'to a propulsive rhythm that gives it a swinging quality'. Asante argues that these forms often reflect African myths. For example, the gliding or dragging step suggests the connection of humans to the earth, which is regarded generally by Africans as friendly and benevolent. It is for this reason that dance points not only towards aesthetic and sacred images, but contains ethical elements solidifying the values of the community.

BOOK REVIEWS

It will be clear from this necessarily brief overview that *African Dance* provides a rich and valuable resource for the many disciplines engaged in African studies. The book's choice of dance as a medium for analysis is justified in the Foreword by Sir Rex Nettleford, the noted Jamaican choreographer. He explains that Africans have been characterised by Westerners as 'licentious, savage and heathenistic', an attitude confirmed to the Western observer by the performance of African dance forms. He adds that in-depth research can dispel such perceptions while providing at the same time firm evidence that 'Africans have not been short on the complexity of the creative process and the sustainability of what the human being anywhere can produce from the individual and collective creative imagination and intellect'. If this book does nothing more than rectify the negative characterisations of African societies as noted by Nettleford, it will have achieved a great deal indeed. Fortunately, it does much more than this by producing a thorough and convincing account of dance as an integral, persistent and dynamic cultural expression throughout Africa and among the African diaspora.

James L. Cox